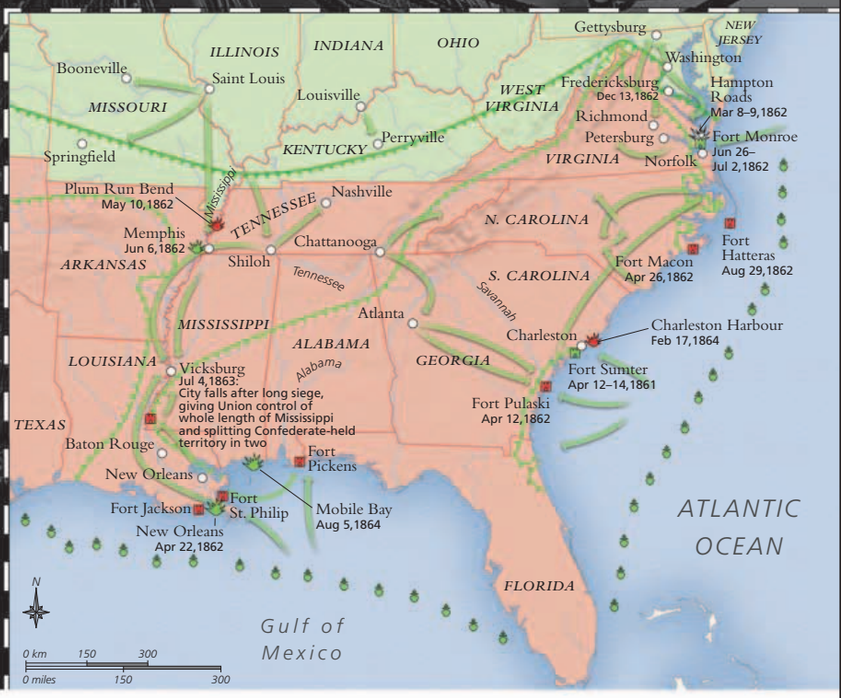
THE AMERICAN CIVIL WAR

THE WAR FOUGHT in 1861–65 between the 11 Confederate secessionist states of the South and the Union forces of the United States government (the North) was fueled by their opposing views on slavery. Although largely decided on land, naval warfare also played a part. The Union, by far the stronger in naval terms, established a blockade of the Southern coast. The South used fast ships to run the blockade and commerce raiders to attack Northern shipping at sea. Small flotillas of paddle-wheel steamers fought for control of the major rivers. Occurring at a transitional point in naval technology, the war spawned a variety of experimental craft, from proto-submarines—used by the South to challenge the blockade—to ironclad "monitors." Overall, the Union had the better of the conflict at sea, as on land, because of superior resources of every kind.



THE AMERICAN CIVIL WAR 1861–1865

The naval war began with the Confederates' bombardment of Fort Sumter in April 1861. From then on, the war centered on the Union blockade of the ports and its attempts to take the forts along the Mississippi. When the latter fell, the Confederate States were effectively cut in half.

KEY

- Union states 1861
- Confederate states 1861
- State border
- Union front line December 1861
- Union front line December 1863
- Union fort
- Confederate fort
- Union blockade
- Union attack/ landing
- Union victory
- Confederate victory
- Inconclusive battle

THE FORCING OF THE MISSISSIPPI FORTS

A major strategic objective of the Union in the early stages of the war was to wrest control of the lower Mississippi River from the Confederates. In February 1862 Flag Officer David Farragut was entrusted with the capture of New Orleans. He was to take a task force, the West Gulf Blockading Squadron, across the sandbars at the mouth of the Mississippi and up the river past the Confederate strongholds of Fort Jackson and Fort St. Philip. The Confederates had blocked the river at the line of the forts with sunken hulks linked by a chain. In principle Farragut's unarmored sloops would be stopped by this obstacle and pulverized by the forts' heavy guns.



THE MISSISSIPPI FORTS

Date	April 18–24, 1862
Location	Mississippi River, near New Orleans
Result	Union victory

COMBATANTS

CONFEDERACY	UNION

COMMANDERS

John K Mitchell	**David G Farragut**

FORCES

Ships: 12 vessels including 2 ironclad rams	**Ships:** 8 steam sloops, 9 gunboats, 19 mortar schooners

LOSSES

Men: 782 dead and wounded **Ships:** 13	**Men:** 37 killed, 149 wounded **Ships:** 1

RUNNING THE GAUNTLET

Farragut had 19 barges mounting mortars capable of firing shells of up to 200 lb. He also had transports carrying 15,000 troops to attack forts on land if needed. The mortars began their bombardment on the morning of April 18. More than a thousand shells a day raining down on the forts caused much damage, but showed no signs of silencing their guns. Farragut decided to force a passage regardless.

In the early hours of April 24, in total darkness, his 17 sloops and gunboats weighed anchor and steamed up river toward the barrier. Two gunboats had earlier succeeded in raiding the obstacle and opening a small navigable passage. Through this gap the Union ships began to pass in single file. At 3:40 a.m. the moon rose and more than a hundred guns opened up from the forts upon the sloops and gunboats revealed below. The Union mortars provided counter-fire upon the batteries; a rag-tag assemblage of Confederate gunboats behind the barrier joined in the firing; and rafts heaped with burning pitch and pine were released to float down on the Yankees' wooden ships. The ships in the center and rear of Farragut's file took a heavy battering from the forts' guns, but only one was disabled and two others forced to turn back.

CSS *Governor Moore* and CSS *Jackson*, cottonclads (gunboats with bales of cotton as armor) succeeded in ramming USS *Varuna*. The oddest vessel in the battle, CSS *Manassas*, a cigar-shaped ironclad ram, carried out a series of attacks before she ran aground and was destroyed by fire from the steamer USS *Mississippi*. On April 25 the Union squadron steamed into New Orleans. The fall of the city was a major blow to the Confederacy. Farragut was rewarded with the rank of rear-admiral—the first officer in the US Navy so designated.



Pennant
This pennant belonged to the Confederate navy vessel CSS *McRae*, which fought Farragut's fleet at the Mississippi forts. Each star represents a Confederate state.